



The bottom-up approach: "As the number of Tests increase, we may see a new domestic tournament for long-form cricket," Smriti Mandhana said, before the Test against England.

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inter-zonal level, which gives an opportunity to at least 15 girls from each zone. So 75 girls at least get a taste of the longest version of the game, which will definitely help fine-tune basic skills in the format," Kulkarni explains.

"At the domestic level, red-ball cricket can come up at the junior or age group levels so that you're not thrown into the deep end when the format comes up later in your career, as is the case with the U16 boys, who get a feel for it early on. A good phase for more red-ball cricket is the U23 phase. They'd be stronger physically; they would have had an idea of the two-day format at the U16 level and white-ball cricket. And they would be able to fine-tune their game better. With the advent of the Women's Premier League, we will

have more kids taking up cricket and white-ball cricket. Playing all formats should be done to fit a purpose, rather than blindly making all formats available. A balance is key," Raman states.

Pressure of expectations

Before one knows it, India plays another red-ball fixture against Alyssa Healy-led Australia. The Aussies play their 78th Test fixture against an Indian side that has shown great promise in the last three Tests it has played, all in the last two years. While the tape will play a similar tune at the end of that exercise around December 24, a tussle between two great rivals awaits, with a lesser-experienced India going in with a marginal upper hand.

"With these results fresh in the mind, pressure is on India, particularly because you're playing at home. The girls have created expectations. People are used to seeing you doing that well—a pressure Australia knows too well," Raman concludes.



Highlights

India beat England by 347 runs, the side's first victory over England on home soil in the format

Three Indian players made their debut in this Test - Jemimah Rodrigues (68, 27), Shubha Satheesh (69), Renuka Singh Thakur (two wickets), no debuts for England

Deepti Sharma's 9/39 match figures are the best by an Indian spinner in Women's Tests, going past Harmanpreet Kaur's 9/85 vs South Africa in Mysore in 2014

This was Harmanpreet's first victory as Test skipper, in her first game as Test captain

England batted only for 63 overs in total in this Test match; of 20 English wickets that fell, 13 fell to spin

India's win was its sixth in 39 Tests (has six losses, 27 draws in the format)

India's margin of victory is only the second instance of a 300-plus run victory in women's Tests, surpassing the previous high of a 309-run win by Sri Lanka vs Pakistan in 1998.